7.3 Archaeological landscape in Kurese, Estonia

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Location and surroundings

The village of Kurese is in the southwestern part of Estonia, in Pärnu County, Lääneranna Municipality, in the West-Estonian lowlands. The post-glacial land reclamation of the area began around 9300 cal BC. Kurese is in the central-southern part of the lowland, where the lowland lime plains alternate with large swamps and marshes. The lime plains are covered by thin soil (Arold 2005, p.295–308). The village is 20 km from the present coast.

Lääneranna municipality includes seven historical parishes, Kurese village is in the largest of them (Fig.21), Mihkli parish. The area was Christianised at the beginning of the 13th century, but the parish division probably dates to the pre-Christian era, i.e. churches were established in the old centres of settlement.

The centre of the later Mihkli parish in the Late Iron Age was the rural stronghold of Soontagana on a marsh island, which dates to the 7th–8th centuries and the peak of its use dates from the 11th to the 13th century (Tõnisson 2008, p.266–269). The village of Kurese, the closest settlement to the stronghold, was first mentioned in written sources in 1534, but archaeological evidence suggests that agricultural settlement there began as early as the Bronze Age (1750–500 BCE). From the 8th–9th century onwards, settlement has been continuous (Mandel 2022, p.216–226).

Before World War Two, Kurese had 23 farms. In the post-war years, i.e. during the occupation of the Republic of Estonia by the Soviet Union, there were many resistance fighters, the so-called forest-brothers, living in the Estonian forests. There were also many of them in the Kurese region, which is why the village was hit particularly hard by Soviet repression – most of the inhabitants were deported to Siberia. The village then became deserted, the last inhabitant died in 1973. The village's land was unsuitable for Soviet period large-scale agriculture, and therefore remained unaffected by land improvement.

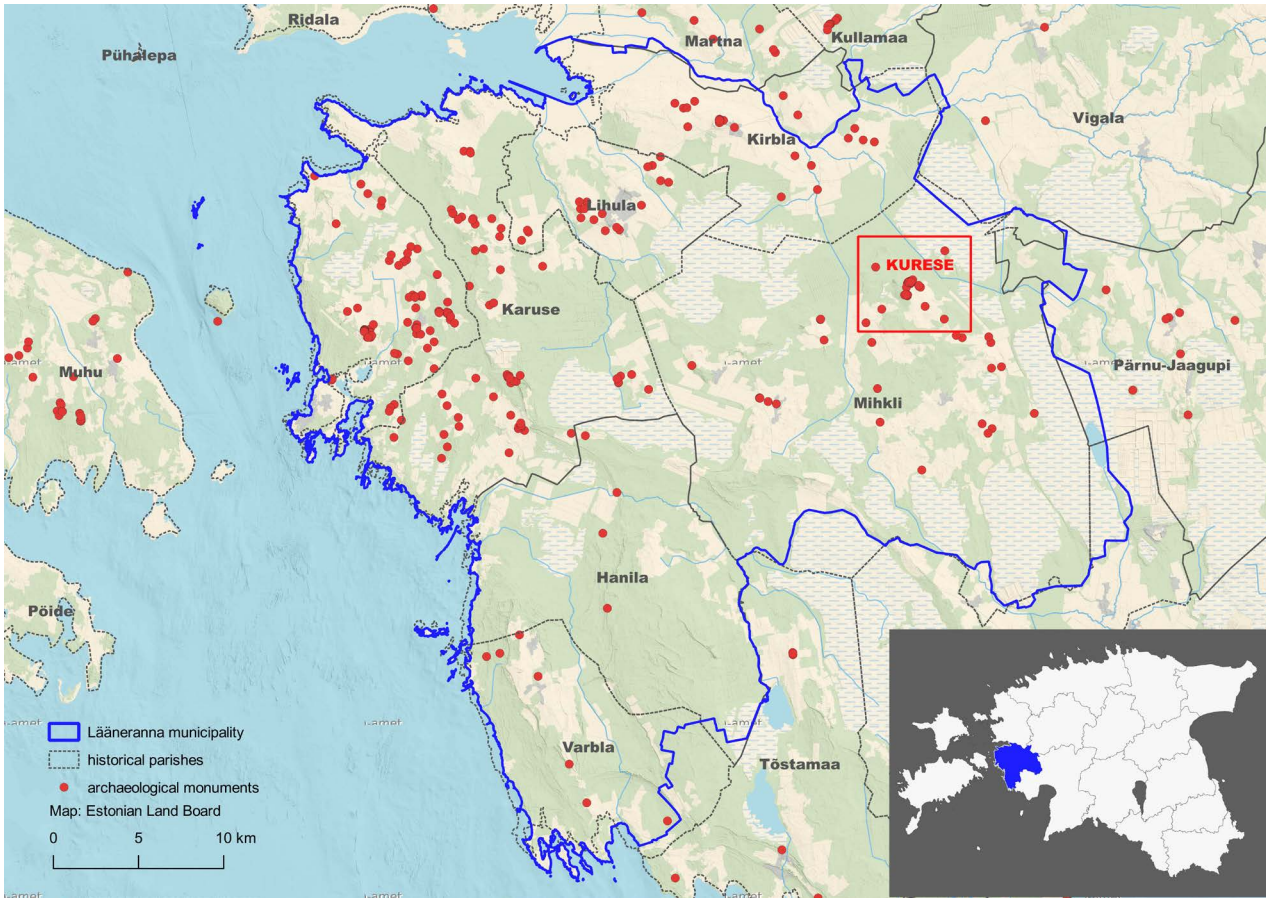

Figure 21: The map of Lääneranna municipality, historical parishes, and the location of Kurese village.

Today, all the farmhouses in the village are dilapidated, and in the overgrown courtyards only the limestone remains of collapsed stoves and walls can be seen. However, stone fences have been largely preserved and the village road is passable. The village's arable land had been overgrown, but over the last 20 years it has been reclaimed as pasture and kilometres of stone fences have been restored.

Reasons for assessment

Since the end of the 18th century, Soontagana stronghold has been repeatedly described by historians. The first small archaeological excavations were carried out in 1895, but the most thorough excavations were carried out in 1965–1971. At that time, about 400 m^2 of rampart and courtyard area in the eastern part of the stronghold were excavated. The village of Kurese is located about 2.5 km south-west of the stronghold, and a historic bog road between the village and the bog island has been preserved.

The Soontagana stronghold was placed under state protection in 1925, a stone grave and a small part of the ancient fields of Kurese village in 1973 and a cup-marked stone in 1979. A small part of the village of Kurese was placed under nature protection in 1976 (Environment Portal), the whole village was listed as landscape reserve in 2007 (Protection Rules 2007). The purpose of the reserve is to preserve heritage landscapes, habitat types and several protected species.

After the restoration of the Republic of Estonia, property reform took place – real estate seized by the Soviet regime was returned to its rightful owners. It was possible to reclaim the property or receive compensation for it. Land that the rightful owners did not want back could be privatised by others.

The village of Kurese had been abandoned in its entirety, and it seemed to most of the descendants of the former owners that it would be very hard to restart former land use, so nature conservation specialist Urmas Vahur managed to buy up most of the land in Kurese. In 1998, the new owner started restoring the marshland – clearing the former hay meadows and pastures from the hedgerow revealed more ancient clearance cairns, stone graves, strongholds, ramparts, and cup-marked stones (Paluoja, 2019). Vahur invited Mati Mandel, an archaeologist from the Estonian History Museum, to help him identify, describe and study the discovered sites. The work started in 2005, with more in-depth research taking place between 2015 and 2020 (Mandel et al, 2016; Mandel, 2017, 2018, 2019; Mandel and Allmäe, 2021).

Vahur proposed to the National Heritage Board (NHB) already in 2006 to declare the core of the village of Kurese and the surrounding land as a heritage conservation area, because in addition to the individual monuments, the entire historical structure of the village is uniquely well preserved. At the time, the NHB and the Ministry of Culture did not consider its designation as a heritage conservation area justified, as it was already under nature protection as a landscape conservation area, and they did not wish to apply double protection. However, upon a new application by Vahur in 2015, the NHB started the procedure for the designation of the Kurese ancient sites as monuments, as the restrictions resulting from the landscape protection area were not sufficient to preserve the special values of Kurese. For example, it could not be used to regulate the activities of hobby searchers-detectorists. As a result of the lengthy procedure, 26 archaeological sites in the village of Kurese were entered in the register of cultural monuments in 2018. They, together with the previously protected monuments and the Soontagana stronghold, were granted a common buffer zone of almost 900 hectares.

To summarise, the reason for the reassessment was, on the one hand, the richness and integrity of the archaeological heritage elements discovered during the archaeological survey of the landscape, and, on the other hand, the need to establish rules for detectorists and for possible development, i.e. should there be an interest in using the village land for something other than agriculture. The owner's exceptional persistence in highlighting and presenting the values of Kurese was certainly a key factor in the whole process.

Legal background of heritage protection in Estonia

Under the Estonian Heritage Conservation Act (HCA), it is possible to declare sites of cultural value as monuments (archaeology, architecture, art, history, technology, natural sites) or to designate heritage conservation areas covering several sites and structures. In Estonia, the medieval town centres and the surrounding Early Modern and Modern suburbs have been recognised as heritage conservation areas,

as well as a rural area near the capital city Tallinn-Rebala, a well-preserved historic-agricultural structure comprising several villages.

In addition, a buffer zone may be established for monuments and heritage conservation areas to ensure that they are preserved in a suitable environment. The constraints on the landowner are greater for monuments and less for the owner of the buffer zone (Fig.22).

As of 2019, the NHB itself is allowed to take archaeological sites into lighter protection as protected archaeological sites. In that case the landowner will only be required to carry out an archaeological survey prior to excavation, and detecting is also prohibited, but the NHB cannot require the preservation of archaeological heritage features. Working out the procedure for the listing of protected archaeological sites took a lot of time for the NHB, which is why the first three protected archaeological sites were listed only in 2023. Accordingly, it is not possible to describe the efficiency of such protection as there is no sufficiently representative practice yet.

However, the HCA lays down an obligation to preserve monuments – everyone must refrain from any activity that may endanger, damage, or destroy a monument. The law also says that a monument may be used in a way that is appropriate for the needs of the modern age, but not in a way that might endanger the preservation of the monument or parts of it.

An archaeological monument is defined by law as remains, things or a set of things of human activity and other traces which indicate the multiple layers of time on a cultural landscape, and which provide scientific information on the history of mankind and human relations with the natural environment. The HCA specifically states that the archaeological cultural layer is an important part of an archaeological monument. Consequently, restrictions on archaeological monuments relate to construction, excavation and other earthworks, as well as felling and afforestation. These activities are not prohibited, but the owner must negotiate the planned works with the NHB and obtain its consent. The NHB must make a judgement on a case-by-case basis as to whether the proposed work

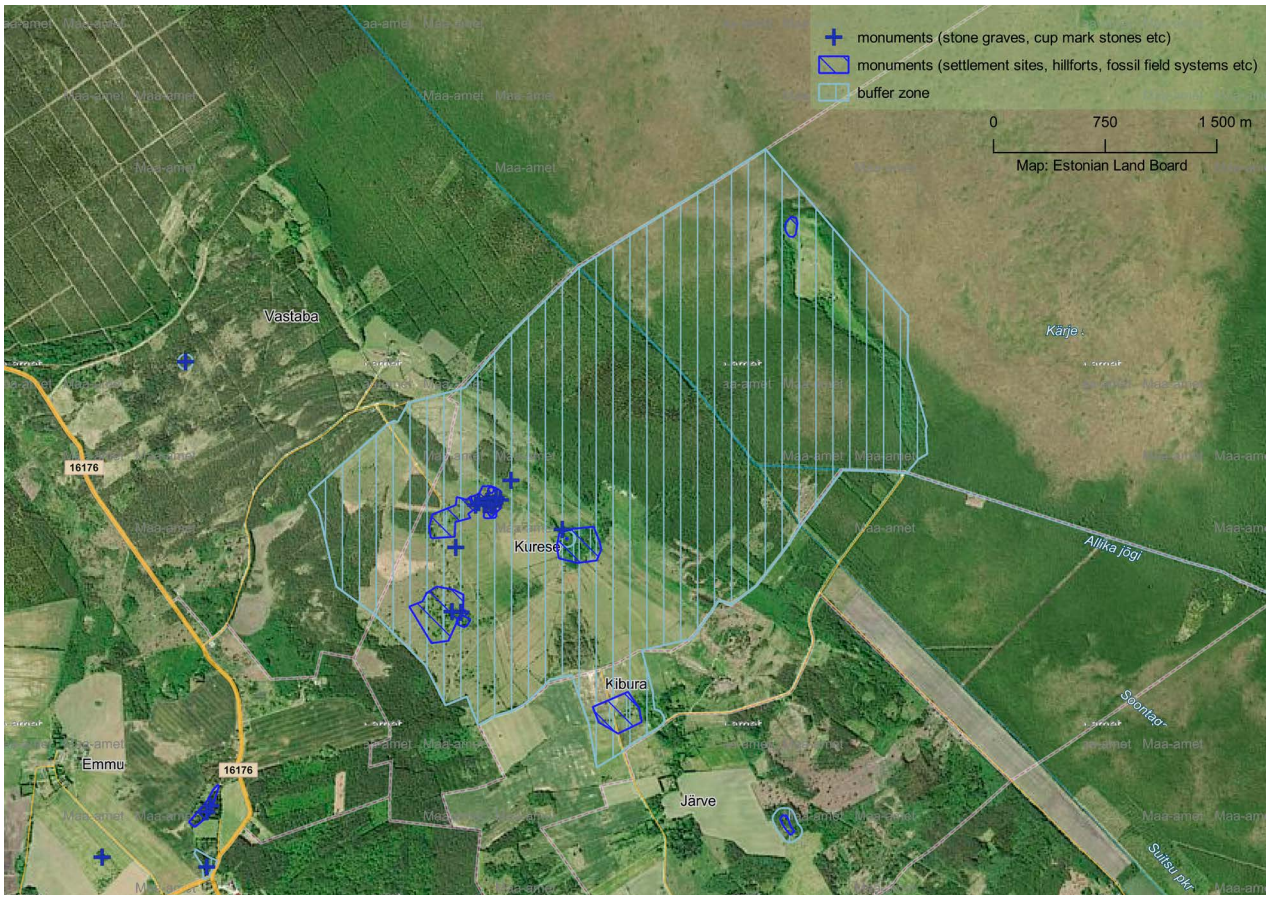

Figure 22: The common buffer zone of archaeological monuments of Kurese village and Soontagana stronghold and the bog island.